PART II · TIME · TIPS

# When the rhythm slips

A rhythm that slips is nearly always a beat that was not counted. Find which beat, count it out loud, and the rest of the bar usually falls into place.

TIP

### What you notice, what to check

| WHAT YOU NOTICE | CHECK | TURN TO |
|---|---|---|
| It speeds up or slows down | **the pulse**: count one bar aloud before you start | p. 50 |
| A rest gets skipped | **the rest**: it is counted just like a note | p. 53 |
| Long notes come out short | **the hold**: count every beat of a minim, dot or tie | p. 56 |
| The bar feels too long or too short | **the time signature**: how many counts, which note is one | p. 59 |
| An off-beat note lands on the beat | **the "&"**: keep the beat in your foot and count it | p. 68 |

## Four ways to steady a rhythm

1. **Count out loud**
   Say the counts while you play, not in your head: a slip you can hear is a slip you can fix.

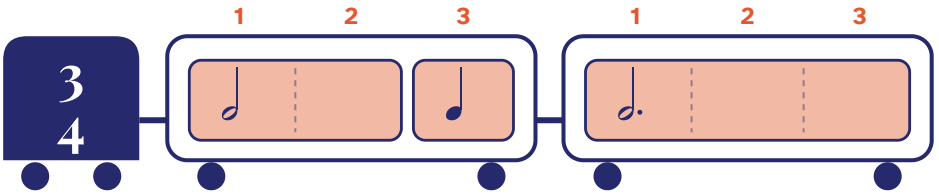
2. **Tap, then play**
   Tap the rhythm on the lid and say the counts; play only when the tapping is steady.

3. **Walk the beat**
   Step the pulse while you clap the rhythm, so the beat lives in your feet.

4. **Split the beat**
   For dots and quavers, count "1 & 2 &": the extra "&" shows exactly where each note goes.

EXAMPLE

### Count the long notes




1. **Say 1 2 3** once through before you play, to feel the beat.
2. **The minim books seats 1 and 2:** keep saying "2" while it sounds.
3. **The dotted minim books all three:** let go on the next "1", not before.

Long notes are where counting slips: **say every seat** they book.

THINK OF IT Like a dance partner: the beat leads, the rhythm follows.